Haligric Research Integration Series

People of the Ice and the Sea Woman

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

The Sacred Traditions of the Inuit, Yupik, and Iñupiat Peoples of the Circumpolar North

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Across the top of the world, from Chukotka through Alaska, the Canadian Arctic, and Greenland, the Inuit and their Yupik and Iñupiat relatives built a spiritual world with no eternal punishments and no ruling god — only a web of persons, human and otherwise, bound by taboo and reciprocity to the animals that let themselves be killed.

At the bottom of the sea lives a woman with no fingers, and when hunters break the old rules, she keeps the seals in her hair until someone braves the journey down to comb it out.

This is a religion built for survival at forty below: of angakkuq who bind themselves in cords and fly to the moon, of amulets numbering in the dozens on a single child, of two women pressed mouth to mouth trading rhythms until one of them laughs.

Missionaries called it dying. It was never entirely gone.

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Introduction — People of the Ice and the Sea Woman

The Inuit, together with their close relatives the Yupik of Alaska and the Russian Far East and the Iñupiat of northern Alaska, inhabit one of the most physically demanding environments ever permanently settled by human beings: the circumpolar Arctic, stretching from the Chukchi Peninsula across Alaska and the Canadian Arctic Archipelago to Greenland. Their ancestors, carriers of the Thule culture, spread rapidly across this entire range roughly a thousand years ago, in some areas absorbing or displacing the earlier Dorset culture whose people appear in Inuit oral tradition as the Tuniit or Sivullirmiut.

Inuit religion, as documented extensively by ethnographers such as Knud Rasmussen and Franz Boas beginning in the late nineteenth century, has no supreme creator god, no fixed pantheon in the sense familiar from state religions, and critically, no system of eternal reward or punishment after death. Instead it describes a cosmos populated by countless persons — human, animal, and other-than-human — whose relationships are governed by respect, taboo, and reciprocity rather than worship in a conventional sense.

Origins and the First Inuit

Many Inuit oral traditions describe the first man and woman, Uumarnituq and Aakulujjuusi, as the originators of childbirth, adult womanhood, and death itself — establishing the basic conditions of human life rather than creating the world from nothing. Other traditions describe a girl named Siqiniq who became the sun, fleeing her brother who became the moon, an origin story that also explains the perpetual, unresolved chase of sun and moon across the sky.

Archaeologically, Inuit ancestors are understood to descend from the Thule culture, which expanded eastward from Alaska roughly a thousand years ago, bringing dog sleds, umiaq and kayak boat technology, and toggling harpoons that allowed sustained whale hunting — a technological and economic shift that underlies much of later Inuit ceremonial life, since whale, seal, and caribou hunting sit at the center of the taboo system described below.

Cosmology and the Spirit World

Sila (also Silap Inua) personifies air, weather, and a diffuse cosmic power that resides within all people; among the Netsilik, Sila was imagined as an enormous, once-infantile being born from the deaths of giants. Sedna — also called Sanna, Nuliajuk, Arnakuagsak, or Arnapkapfaaluk depending on the region — is the most widely venerated figure across the Inuit world: mistress of the sea and mother of all marine mammals, an orphaned girl mistreated by her community whose severed fingers became the seals, walruses, and whales that hunters depend on. When taboos are broken, Sedna is said to keep the sea animals tangled in her hair at the bottom of the ocean, withholding them from hunters until an angakkuq undertakes the dangerous spirit-journey down to comb it out and restore the game.

Other major figures include Nanook, master of the polar bears; Tekkeitsertok, master of the caribou; Pinga, goddess of the hunt, strength, fertility, and medicine; the Moon Man (Tarqiup Inua, or Aningaat), who receives human souls after death and whose wrath, in Greenlandic tradition, could be provoked by taboo violation; and Anguta, who gathers the dead and carries them to a yearlong sleep in the underworld. Malevolent or dangerous beings include Amaguq (Amarok), a wolf spirit that claims solitary nighttime hunters; Aipaloovik, an evil sea god associated with death; and Qallupilluit, monstrous sea-dwelling beings said to carry off disobedient children from the shore ice — a figure still invoked today, half in earnest and half as folklore, to keep children safely away from thin ice.

The Soul, the Body, and the Taboo System

Inuit theology generally describes a person as composed of multiple soul-elements rather than one indivisible soul: a life force or personal spirit (iñuusiq/iḷitqusiq), a name-soul (atiq) capable of passing to a newborn relative and effectively reincarnating, and a free soul that can leave the body during sleep or trance, appearing to others as a shadow or a flicker of fire. Among the Caribou Inuit, a child's soul (tarneq) was considered dangerously fragile and required the protective guardianship of a deceased ancestor's name-soul until the child was old enough to hold it securely.

Because animals were understood to possess their own inua — their own indwelling person or soul — hunting was governed by an extensive taboo system meant to maintain right relationship with the animals whose voluntary self-sacrifice sustained human life. Breaking these taboos was believed to cause game scarcity, illness, or bad weather, requiring ritual reconciliation, often through an angakkuq's intervention. Amulets, whose protective power derived from an associated spirit, were worn extensively — some individuals, particularly among the Netsilik, carried dozens at once, occasionally to the point of restricting their own movement, while inherited ancestral names were themselves treated as a form of protection.

Suspected witches could be tested by an angakkuq, sometimes through the belief that a witch's body would not bleed when stabbed; a tupilaq — an animated killing-object assembled by an angakkuq from hair, moss, or bone and directed at an enemy — represents the darker, sanctioned end of this same spiritual technology.

The Angakkuq — Shamans of the Spirit World

The angakkuq (plural angakkuit; recorded historically as angakok or, in Danish colonial sources, åndemaner, "spirit-invoker") served as the primary ritual specialist mediating between the human and spirit worlds. Both men and women could become angakkuq, though men predominated in most regions; on St. Lawrence Island, ritual specialists who did not conform to ordinary gender roles were in some accounts considered especially powerful practitioners.

Apprenticeship, often lasting up to a decade in Greenland (though sometimes compressed to a single winter among the Caribou Inuit), involved dietary restriction, secrecy, and solitary trials in remote country — in one documented case, an apprentice rubbed stones toward the sun for three days until a helping spirit appeared; in another, the apprentice called out for three days until a spirit's voice answered. Successful apprentices acquired tuurngait (helping spirits, also tornait or tornat), frequently housed in small carved figures, and an inner spiritual light that, among Iglulik peoples, was explicitly connected to the Moon Man.

Séances typically took place at night in darkened dwellings, with the angakkuq entering trance to diagnose illness (commonly attributed to soul-loss) via qilaneq, or 'head-lifting' divination, in which a diviner lifted the patient's head on a cord or belt and asked yes-or-no questions, interpreting the head's weight as the spirits' answer. In cases of serious illness or famine, the angakkuq might undertake a full spirit journey — to the Moon, to the land of the dead, or down to Sedna at the bottom of the sea — while the community sang to encourage the traveling soul. Some performances included Arctic variants of the shaking-tent rite, in which a bound angakkuq demonstrated supernatural release from cords as proof of spirit assistance.

Ceremonies, Divination, and Sacred Practice

Among the Yupik of the Bering Sea region, the bladder festival marked one of the year's central ceremonies: the inflated bladders of seals, walrus, and caribou killed that year — believed to house the animals' inua — were ceremonially returned to the ocean through a hole in the sea ice, a rite meant to release the animals' souls so they could be reborn and again offer themselves to hunters the following year.

Tattooing, particularly among Netsilik and other women, was understood to confer power in this life and to shape a woman's destination and status after death; specific tattoo patterns marked a woman's readiness for marriage or her accomplishments. Ritual games played by children, called tunangusartut, mimicked angakkuq behavior and formulaic speech, functioning as an informal transmission of spiritual vocabulary and expectation to the next generation.

Drum dancing — accompanied by a large, shallow frame drum (qilaut) struck from underneath — remains one of the coast's most enduring ceremonial forms, used historically for storytelling, competitive song-duels used to settle disputes without violence, and celebration, and it continues today at community gatherings and cultural festivals across the Arctic.

Key Figures and Texts

Knud Rasmussen, a Greenlandic-Danish explorer and ethnographer of part-Inuit descent, led the Fifth Thule Expedition (1921-1924), an extraordinary multi-year, dog-sled-based survey of Inuit communities from Greenland to Siberia; the resulting Report of the Fifth Thule Expedition remains one of the single most important ethnographic records of pre-Christian Inuit belief, cosmology, and shamanic practice ever assembled, and is still a primary source for researchers and Inuit communities reconstructing pre-contact tradition today.

Franz Boas, working among the Baffin Island Inuit in the 1880s, produced early foundational ethnographic accounts (including The Central Eskimo) that, alongside Rasmussen's later work, anchor most academic and community understanding of classical Inuit cosmology.

In the contemporary period, the Inuit Cultural Institute (founded 1975) and the creation of the self-governing Canadian territory of Nunavut in 1999 mark the two most significant institutional expressions of pan-Inuit cultural revival, providing structures for language preservation, traditional knowledge documentation, and cultural authority independent of earlier colonial administration. Tanya Tagaq, a Polaris Music Prize-winning throat singer (2014), is among the most internationally visible contemporary culture-bearers, having brought katajjaq into global contemporary music while explicitly foregrounding its Inuit origins and politics.

Self-Care, Wellness, and Daily Practice

Katajjaq, Inuit throat singing, is traditionally performed by two women standing face to face, often holding each other's arms, one leading with a short rhythmic vocal pattern and the other filling the gaps with a second pattern, using both voiced and breathed sounds that imitate wind, running water, and animal calls. Historically understood as a vocal game played by women while men were away hunting rather than formal music or ceremony, it is competitive by design — the objective is to outlast one's partner without breaking rhythm or laughing — and functioned as both entertainment and a form of social bonding and skill transmission between women. Suppressed for decades by missionaries who considered it inappropriate or spiritually suspect, katajjaq has undergone a vigorous revival since the late twentieth century; Quebec formally designated Nunavik throat singing its first officially recognized element of intangible cultural heritage in 2014.

Country food — traditionally hunted and gathered food such as seal, caribou, arctic char, and berries — continues to be described by Inuit women, in recent qualitative health research from Nunavut, explicitly as 'soul food': a source of physical nourishment inseparable from mental and spiritual well-being, cultural identity, and connection to land and ancestors, and a central focus of contemporary Inuit food-security and public-health programming.

Land-based healing programs, now formally integrated into Inuit and broader Indigenous mental wellness services across the Canadian North, deliberately combine time on the land, traditional skill transmission (hunting, harvesting, skin preparation), elder mentorship, and, where communities choose it, drum dancing and storytelling, as an explicit therapeutic alternative or complement to conventional clinical mental health care — a direct institutional descendant of the older understanding that human well-being depends on right relationship with land, animals, and community.

Legacy and Influence

The pan-Inuit cultural revival movement that gathered strength from the 1970s onward — culminating institutionally in the 1999 creation of Nunavut, Canada's largest and newest territory, governed with substantial Inuit political authority — is frequently cited internationally as a model for indigenous self-determination achieved through negotiated land claims rather than armed conflict.

Inuit throat singing's global recognition, including Tanya Tagaq's 2014 Polaris Music Prize and Quebec's 2014 intangible-heritage designation for Nunavik katajjaq, has substantially raised international awareness of Inuit culture well beyond the specialist ethnographic literature that had previously been its primary record.

Knud Rasmussen's and Franz Boas's ethnographic corpora remain foundational reference points not only for academic circumpolar studies but for Inuit communities themselves engaged in language and tradition revitalization, since so much of classical angakkuq practice and cosmology had, by the mid-twentieth century, ceased to be openly transmitted.

Christianization and Its Aftermath — Controversies and Fairness

Sustained missionization began with the first Anglican mission post in the Canadian Arctic in 1894 and the first Roman Catholic post in 1912, following two centuries of more sporadic contact dating to seventeenth-century European voyages. Inuit communities in many areas initially showed considerable openness to incorporating Christian elements alongside existing spirit beliefs, and angakkuq in some regions, notably East Greenland, continued practicing largely unhindered well into the early twentieth century even as Danish colonial authorities as early as 1746 had formally complained about ongoing shamanic activity. By the time of intensive twentieth-century missionization and government-driven settlement policy, however, most Inuit communities had formally converted, and by the 1930s the angakkuq tradition in its classical form had effectively ended among Polar Inuit in northwest Greenland; as of the 2021 Canadian census, 71 percent of Canadian Inuit identify as Christian, illustrating both the scale of the change and its incompleteness as a total replacement of prior belief.

Canada's residential school system, which forcibly removed Inuit, First Nations, and Métis children from their families for much of the twentieth century, is now formally recognized as a National Historic Event, with well-documented harms to language transmission, family structure, and spiritual continuity; Inuit leaders and organizations continue to press, as of 2024 and 2025, for fuller government acknowledgment of this history, and a 2025 Canadian Senate vote against a residential-school-denialism clause drew public criticism from Inuit leaders and Indigenous scholars as a setback in that ongoing reckoning. Inuit-authored accounts of residential school impacts continue to be published and discussed as part of an active, unresolved process of truth-telling that runs alongside the cultural revival described above rather than following neatly after it.

Closing

By the early twentieth century outside observers were certain Inuit religion would vanish entirely, and for the angakkuq tradition in its classical form, they were largely right. But the songs did not vanish, and the taboo-logic of respect for the animal person did not vanish, and neither did the conviction that the ice, the moon, and the woman under the sea are still owed something.

Nunavut now governs itself. Throat singers who could once be punished for the sound now win national prizes for it. The reckoning with what residential schools took is still underway and still contested in the halls of government.

Grand rising to the people of the ice and the sea woman — the comb is still being passed down to untangle what was broken.